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THE THEME AND THE NARRATOR OF "THE GREAT GATSBY"

THOMAS A. HANZO

OF THE TWO MOST PROMINENT CAREERS which figure in F. Scott Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby,* Jay Gatsby's is a variation of the American success story, and Nick Carraway's is an example, differing from others in locale and therefore also in implication, of the provincial American's career in a society more sophisticated than his own.[1] Fitzgerald was able to combine the types through the convention of the first person narration, but Nick's fate has been generally ignored in detailed criticisms of the book. Gatsby and his dream, in these interpretations, are Fitzgerald's subjects, and through them is seen his ultimate subject, "fundamentally, the heterogeneous nature of American culture," as a recent article has it.[2] Lionel Trilling has suggested a use of this conception by Fitzgerald which, by a slight distortion, I should like to develop for my own purposes: "He [Fitzgerald] exaggerated the idea of society and his dependence upon it in order, we may say, to provide a field for the activity of his conscience, for the trial of his self."[3] Gatsby surely represents one of Fitzgerald's trials of self, an incomplete one, however, in contrast with the less dramatic experience of Nick Carraway. Fitzgerald's intention cannot be clarified, nor the significance of his achievement grasped, without our sharing with Nick the trial of his self and the activity of his conscience in that society of which Gatsby is only the most notable part.

When Carraway's voice introduces and concludes the action, Fitzgerald makes us conscious of the narrator, whose role may first be outlined by a comparison in which he acts the foil to Gatsby. We may begin with a difference which Fitzgerald would rightly have approved: Gatsby is rich, Nick relatively poor. Gatsby is alone, mysterious, obsessed; Nick makes friends easily, his life is ordinary, and he is quite sane. Gatsby is without conscience except perhaps where Daisy is concerned, and Nick subjects every act and motive to the

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[1] The Americans of Henry James' novels are examples of the type; James dealt, according to Yvor Winters, "with the American, uprooted from his native usages, and confronted with the alien usages of a subtle and ancient society." "Maule's Well, or Henry James and the Relation of Morals to Manners," *In Defense of Reason* (New York, 1947), p. 312.

[2] W. M. Frohock, "Morals, Manners, and Scott Fitzgerald," *Southwest Review,* XL (Summer, 1955), p. 224.

[3] "Fitzgerald Plain," *The New Yorker,* 26:4 (February 3, 1951), p. 80.

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scrutiny of a lively moral sense. Gatsby learns nothing in the course of the novel, or at least until his doom has been secured, for he decided too early what he wanted and strove for it with a determination which subordinated all other demands. Although Nick is thirty years old in the summer of 1922, the time of the novel, he is still an adolescent when he settles on Long Island, with an adolescent's memory of the war, and he comes to New York to enter the bond-selling business chiefly because other restless young men are doing the same thing. Nick has no purposes, he thinks of no powers to realize, and only very gradually, not until sometime in 1924, does he come to understand what his New York interlude has meant.

I cannot presume that this view of Carraway's part in the novel constitutes a revolutionary interpretation of *The Great Gatsby*. Arthur Mizener, whose analysis of *The Great Gatsby* has appeared in several forms and is undoubtedly the most widely distributed, approves Fitzgerald's choice of form and recognizes the structural importance of the first-person convention: "By means of this narrator he [Fitzgerald] was able to focus his story."[4] But the novel is the story of Gatsby, "a poor boy from the Middle West," and when Mr. Mizener classifies *The Great Gatsby* as a "tragic pastoral," it is Gatsby who illustrates the difference between the "simple virtue" of the West, and the "sophistication" and "corruption" of the East.[5] The moral distance between the two localities may be measured in more profound ways if we take Nick Carraway as our example and his sensibility and intelligence as the recognizable determinants which inform the story with its meaning. Such a reading of *The Great Gatsby* must also be compared, and at several points, with the interpretation of R. W. Stallman, who, in "Gatsby and the Hole in Time," characterizes Nick as a "defunct arch-priest" and regards the notion that Nick is to be seen as the "moral center of the book" as possible only to the "duped reader."[6] Fitzgerald's intention that we understand clearly what happens to Carraway may be appreciated in the first part of the first chapter. The novel's extraordinary economy requires, at least in its best parts, an attentive reading of detail, and since there are barely two pages in the first section, a close following of the text will not be intolerable.

Nick Carraway begins his story with the recollection that his father advised him to reserve his judgment of others because they may not

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[4] "F. Scott Fitzgerald: The Poet of Borrowed Time," *Critiques and Essays on Modern Fiction*, p. 295. Mr. Mizener, an acute reader of Fitzgerald, is well aware of Nick's moral involvement in the action of *The Great Gatsby*. I can hope to complement his analysis by a fullness of treatment he did not judge necessary.

[5] *Ibid.*, p. 296.

[6] *Modern Fiction Studies*, I (November, 1955), p. 7.

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have had the same "advantages." Nick's tolerance has made him the confidant of some and the victim of others, but to preserve his caution he has always reminded himself that "a sense of the fundamental decencies is parcelled out unequally at birth." Carraway's father has warned him about the difficulties of moral judgment, a difficulty originating in circumstances of origin and inheritance. But conduct, Nick observes, must be principled in some fashion. There is a "limit" to toleration. "Conduct may be founded on the hard rock or on the wet marshes, but after a certain point I don't care what it's founded on." That is, while it may be impossible to fix moral responsibility or to determine derelictions from that responsibility, Nick insists that action reveal some principle and that toleration does not permit indifference. His criticism of the standards and conduct of his Long Island friends has tired him, he concludes; he can wish the world "to stand at a sort of moral attention forever"; he wants no more "riotous" glimpses into the human heart. We should be too hasty if we condemned Nick for an unhealthy curiosity or for pompous self-righteousness. The tone of his narrative is never offensively positive, and we shall see that what may appear to be a peculiar form of pride is actually a serious kind of candor. Nick considers not only his friends, but himself as well. He tells us plainly what should interest us in his tale, and he introduces us to a period of his own life in which he is not entirely blameless and neutral. The quality of plainness, the device of direct relevation, has appeared to R. W. Stallman as the mask of the hypocrite, who is betrayed, symbolically, by his "irregular lawn."[7] To the contrary, Nick's irregularities of behavior, his carelessness, do not escape his judgment; he does not grow more confused but learns to see more clearly what Eastern society and morality are and how he has been corrupted by them.

Nick prepares us for his personal involvement in the action by his next words, when he reveals his own origins, or his reasons for thinking that he had "advantages." He came from a family of "prominent, well-to-do people" who have lived in "this Middle Western city for three generations." They have enjoyed commercial success, act together as a family, and regard the decisions and conduct of their relatives with grave concern. They have inherited the moral seriousness of their Scottish ancestors, sustain their business and social position as a manifestation of their moral superiority, and have passed down to their heirs a strong "sense of the fundamental decencies."

The narrator's part complicates the action. We are expected to realize that what we are told comes to us through his peculiar agency,

[7] *Ibid.*

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and therefore—to complete an obvious matter—our knowledge of the narrator will establish the limits of our knowledge of the whole action. Fitzgerald understood these limitations and in the direct, economical way of *The Great Gatsby* engages the reader at once in the particular interests which the novel should arouse. Immediately after his introductory remarks, Carraway narrates his first visit to the Buchanan household, where he delivers an exact description of a moneyed and corrupt Eastern society in Daisy's despair and in Tom's adulteries.

Here Nick meets Jordan Baker, a professional tennis player who has succumbed to the ennui of the frantic search for novelty and excitement to which she and others of her post-war generation had devoted themselves. She is also a persistent and obvious liar, and Nick soon perceives this fault. Yet he is interested in her, though exactly how intimate they become is only suggested by a scene in which Jordan easily accepts Nick's first attentions. Her unconcern for any standards beyond those of a frank self-indulgence is evidence enough that the two have become lovers. This relationship is Nick's most personal involvement in the dissolution which Jordan represents, and the perception of his share in a common guilt comes with his initial revulsion to his summer's experience, directly after Myrtle Wilson's death. He is suddenly disgusted by the vicious and now violent life about him, but even in his new wisdom, his passion for Jordan has not been completely destroyed. In his last conversation with her, he can feel that he might be "making a mistake" by ending their affair and finally that he is "half in love with her." We learn most about them at this point in Jordan's accusation that Nick is a "bad driver." He is not the person she thought—not what he pretended to be—and she says, "It was careless of me to make such a wrong guess. I thought you were rather an honest, straightforward person. I thought it was your secret pride." Nick answers: "I'm thirty. I'm five years too old to lie to myself and call it honor." It was Nick's pride to feel that he could accept Jordan on her own terms, with her cynicism and her irresponsibility, and yet that he could escape the consequences of that acceptance. But what was subdued or ignored has now erupted, with Gatsby murdered and with Daisy and Tom exposed in their terrible selfishness. It can no longer be honorable for Nick to maintain the pretense that nothing serious is involved in his affair with Jordan. Nick was dishonest because he acted as though he brought no other standards of conduct to judge their liaison with than those which Jordan's hedonism impose; and it is now plain, in his disgust and self-recrimination, that Nick has in fact deceived Jordan. She accuses him of having thought of her all along as he does now, when he has given her up. She is right, of course, and Nick, who is (he tells us) the most honest man

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he knows, admits his twice-compounded duplicity, a duplicity analyzed in a similar way by R. W. Stallman. But he does not accept Nick's understanding of his personal responsibility. When Jordan "calls his bluff," as Stallman puts it, the effect is to make public Nick's own shame, so that, far from being "identified" with Jordan,[8] Nick is separated from her and from her society. He can no longer lie, and he leaves the East, without honor perhaps, but with a new-found vision of his own guilt.

There is another complication in Nick's discovery of his error. Even Jordan Baker, he says, came from the West. All the Westerners —Tom, Daisy, Gatsby, Jordan, and Nick—"possessed some deficiency in common which made us subtly unadaptable to Eastern life." Though the rest may have become more acclimated to the atmosphere of Eastern society than Nick, none is entirely at ease. None can rid himself of that "sense of the fundamental decencies," however attenuated it may have become, which their origins have given them. None can finally be comfortable in the hedonism cultivated by the Eastern representatives of his generation, or at least by those with money and enough intelligence to be disillusioned by the war. After his revulsion, Nick returns to the comparatively rigid morality of his ancestral West and to its embodiment in the manners of Western society. He alone of all the Westerners can return, since the others have suffered, apparently beyond any conceivable redemption, a moral degeneration brought on by their meeting with that form of Eastern society which developed during the twenties.

Nick makes another commitment to the life he at last rejects, a commitment that includes what we should ordinarily take to be his humiliating part in the affair between Gatsby and Daisy. Nick is used and knows it, but his attachment to Gatsby leads him to make another important discovery, however vague it may remain in some respects, about the nature of morality itself. We should ask: What does Nick think of Gatsby? And why? And again a passage at the beginning of the novel will reveal the essential information.

After Nick has explained that there must be limits to his toleration, he excepts Gatsby from his general reaction, "Gatsby, who represented everything for which I have an unaffected scorn." "There was something gorgeous about him, some heightened sensitivity to the promises of life. . . ." Gatsby had "an extraordinary gift for hope, a romantic readiness." Gatsby, Nick says, "turned out all right at the end," and it was not he who drew Nick's scorn, but the "foul dust" which "floated in the wake of his dreams." We learn gradually about Gatsby's dream: about the events of his early life and his peculiar training,

[8] *Ibid.*, p. 8.

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about his obsession, about his impersonal—indeed, royal—view of his own personality, about the reality which his vision of the perfect life must have seemed to him. Now, the capacities which Nick admires are the capacities of will: a tremendous energy to accomplish certain purposes, and a self-imposed delusion which makes those purposes meaningful. The delusion is the vision of Gatsby's life with Daisy, and the purposes are his need for money and social position to make himself worthy of her. Gatsby differs from the others of his time by virtue of these capacities. Whereas the behavior of the Eastern rich, the racketeers, and the Westerners who adopt Eastern ways is restricted and debased by the selfish motives of personal and sensual gratification, Gatsby acts for a good which he conceives, almost absurdly, as being beyond personal interest. Gatsby's last heroism in protection of the mistress of his dream confirms Nick's judgment. Gatsby does turn out all right, while Tom and Daisy sit comfortably at their family table, bound in their private safety. If Gatsby, as Nick says at the end, "felt that he had lost the old warm world, paid a high price for living too long with a single dream," his sacrifice has already been made and his life consummated. He had found a way to live as men had once lived, with a purpose and a meaning which transcended personal fate.

Nick accepts the probability that Gatsby himself realized the insufficiency of his dream. The vision was only Gatsby's and his goal only a personal one, if somehow ennobled, as Nick sees it, by Gatsby's strength of will. Further, Gatsby is a fraud. The structure of appearance erected to impress Daisy is founded on some kind of illegal traffic which only repels her, so that she is lost to Gatsby even before the accident of Myrtle's death. Nor is Nick ever in any doubt that Gatsby has valued only the tawdry and the vain. He is left at last with Gatsby's morality, or rather Gatsby's capacity to live according to a morality, his "romantic readiness." It is this ability which Nick feels that he and the others lack, presumably because of historical circumstance.

That, at least, is what I take to be the meaning of the last words of the novel, on the night when Nick left West Egg forever, and the "inessential houses began to melt away until gradually I became aware of the old island here that flowered once for Dutch sailors' eyes—a fresh, green breast of the new world. Its vanished trees, the trees that had made way for Gatsby's house, had once pandered in whispers to the last and greatest of all human dreams. . . ." In Nick's day, I conclude, such dreams no longer correspond to any reality.[9] They

[9] Edwin S. Fussell suggests that the dream of the Dutch sailors was also "unreal" and relies on the associations of the word *pandered* to develop this theme of the failure of romantic wonder, the quest for youth and success. "Fitzgerald's Brave New World," *ELH*, XIX (1952), p. 298. The interpretation may be allowed, but only, I think, if the

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present no real challenges, and only disillusion, even for a man like Gatsby, can ensue, if a lesser dream like Gatsby's is accepted. When Gatsby "picked out the green light at the end of Daisy's dock," Nick continues, "he did not know that it [his dream] was already behind him." A last contrast may now be made clear between Gatsby and Nick, Gatsby who thought he could remake the past and Nick who knew that it was irretrievably lost and that more than Gatsby's dream was gone with it.

Nick's discovery is that the power of will without the direction of intelligence is a destructive power, that there must be some real end beyond the satisfaction of private desire—however desire may be exalted—to justify the expenditure of life. But he believes too that, except for the anachronistic and fatal instance of Gatsby, the time when such ends could have existed is now done. We can only "beat on, boats against the current, borne back ceaselessly into the past."

Fitzgerald represents the past both as a loss and as a source of strength. It is the record of such deeds springing from such dedication as cannot now be expected, and in the Carraway family tradition, it confers a discipline and standards which, even as survivals of an old morality, may still produce better conduct than Nick witnesses on Long Island. Nick's honesty and his conception of a good existing beyond selfish ends may be only heirlooms, he realizes, honored for sentimental reasons, but they have been given a contemporary, limited reality in his own life. Nick includes his morality in his description of a graceless modern age and reduces his claims on it to the satisfaction of individual conscience. He has no real alternative—in the sense that it may be said to be available to other men—to the selfishness he condemns in Tom or Jordan. He does not speak authoritatively. But while his voice is subdued, it is never unsure. Nick's judgments are firm because he assumes that evil may be clearly enough determined. His hopes are modest because he regards the good only as a private, incommunicable possession. He can assert his criticism and judgment of Eastern society, including the revelation of his own guilt, but he affirms no morality of his own, accepting the circumstances of his birthright rather than affirming its permanent values. That Nick proposes to "save the world by regimenting it,"[10] as R. W. Stallman has it, because he wants the world to be at a "sort of moral attention forever" is a reading which attributes this understandable reaction, this moral inertia, to a rigidity which Nick's private convictions could not support. Fitzgerald—so far as we can discern from the tenor of his narration—expects to meet no disagreement with his perception

old dream be regarded as the "last and greatest." Gatsby's dream was, to repeat, an illusion.

[10] "Gatsby and the Hole in Time," p. 7.

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of evil, but assumes that he and his readers will all be perplexed to find a common good. This combination of conviction and diffidence produces the extraordinary contrast between the effects of cryptic description (as in Gatsby's youthful regimen) and of ideographic device (as in Dr. Ekleburg's eyes) and the quiet and deprecated role of the narrator.

Such an interpretation credits Fitzgerald with a moral seriousness which has, with reason, been challenged. With R. W. Stallman, W. S. Frohock finds Nick "short on moral perspective"[11] and Fitzgerald's style catching the "feeling of things" but combined with a "romantic inability to interpret them."[12] Edwin S. Fussell, on the other hand, defines the story of *The Great Gatsby* and other works as "the work of the imagination in the New World";[13] its failure to discover an objective for the romantic capacity is an American tragedy.[14] Failure, of course, attends Gatsby's career as inexorably as the current which sweeps the boats back into the past, but the failure must be experienced through Nick's moral sense, and his difficulties must be judged not as a lack of moral perspective but as the occasion for moral action of a peculiarly limited sort. Such a reading of Nick's role restores the exphasis which Fitzgerald gave to that moral judgment (developing awkwardly, it is true) which gives the novel its very form. And it may cast some light on the question of what Fitzgerald's early Catholic training may have meant to him:[15] a training which left him with the means to analyze and judge post-war American society even while he had lost the convictions which might have produced something more positive than Nick's retreat to the West.

The Great Gatsby is not a melodrama about Jay Gatsby, but a definition of the senses in which Nick understands the word "great." Its subject is an American morality. It is explored historically through the conflict between the surviving Puritan morality of the West and the post-war hedonism of the East; topically, through characteristic manifestations of American money values; formally and most significantly, through the personal history of a young American provincial whose moral intelligence is the proper source of our understanding and whose career, in the passage from innocence to revaluation, dramatizes the possibility and mode of a moral sanction in contemporary America.

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[11] "Morals, Manners, and Scott Fitzgerald," p. 227.

[12] *Ibid.*, p. 228.

[13] "Fitzgerald's Brave New World," p. 291.

[14] *Ibid.*, p. 297.

[15] See the query by Professor H. W. Hausermann in *Modern Fiction Studies*, II, 2 (May, 1956), pp. 81-82.

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